

RURAL ROADS

Making a Difference

- Road connectivity has increased the accessibility of villagers to markets for their farm produce and changed the cropping pattern from food grain to cash crops
- There has been a growth in on-farm employment opportunities due to increase in cropping intensity
- Employment opportunities outside villages have gone up due to greater mobility
- Public health centres, district hospitals and schools can be easily accessed now by children in villages

WAY TO GO: The road leading to Rahu ka Par in Rajasthan



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conversation, if it can be deemed that, is not known. But in his tongue-in-cheek style, Vajpayee was said to have asked the Maharashtra leader if there was a flyover to connect Bharat with India. Gadkari said yes and related his limited experience in connecting 16,000 villages—including the 100 adivasi villages in Melghat—in Maharashtra. Having dealt with the construction of India's most modern six-lane expressway between Mumbai and Pune, Gadkari knew the maths. Vajpayee suggested he head the National Rural Road Development Committee (NRRDC). This was perhaps the first time when a former state minister was advising the Centre and the scheme was announced by the then-president K.R. Narayanan on October 29, 1999.

NRRDC would perhaps qualify as a Central government committee with the shortest lifespan. By May 2000,

the committee came out with its overview, findings and solutions. According to their report, India's 5.89 lakh villages of varying sizes were inhabited by about 75 per cent of its population and scattered across 3.29 million sq. km. The findings of the committee suggested that every day, 300 pregnant women in India died as they were unable to reach a healthcare centre in time from their village, that lakhs of children couldn't reach schools during the rains and rural incomes stagnated because agricultural produce couldn't reach markets and would perish. A lot of this was known, but not in such shocking detail. Gadkari quoted John F. Kennedy in his report and said, "American roads are good, not because America is rich, but America is rich because American roads are good."

Vajpayee did not wait for any discussion or debate and promptly kicked off the programme. The modalities of a simple funding mechanism were worked out (by charging a cess from diesel users to fund network expansion). The scheme was launched and a few days later, Narayanan announced it to the nation. The NDA government decided that in the first phase, habitations (hamlets) with a population of 1,000 (500 in the case of hill states, tribal and desert areas) and above, would be covered. About 3,68,000 km of new roads were to be constructed and 3,70,000 km to be upgraded. The scheme took off almost instantly and within months, word-of-mouth publicity and relative-talk fuelled the demand for rural roads to such an extent that the government was forced to bring in other agencies and banking institutions to fill in the gaps in funding. While there may have been issues of corruption at the local level, this project is perhaps the most successful poverty alleviation endeavour ever undertaken by any government in independent India.

The statistics are remarkable. Till October 2007, projects worth Rs 42,582 crore to connect 60,556 habitations through 216,950 km of roads have been approved. Already 111,461 km of roads have been built to connect 33,041 habitations.

As with many of India's revolutions—be it the Gujarat milk experiment or liberalisation, one is left wondering why such a great idea couldn't have occurred to somebody earlier. Right now though, India's politicians need to work out why more villages cannot be connected every year. Perhaps it is time to call in Gadkari once again. ■

Rs 42,582

crore was the total worth of projects cleared by the Central government to build roads

3,68,000

kilometres of new roads had to be constructed when the project first took off